



Let the SHOW begin

First it was music, and now it's movies. Digital technology is all set to bring you hassle-free video from the Net to your PC with crystal-clear sound and picture

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Circa 1970: An evening at the movies. Mother dresses the kids for the outing and father takes his car out. At the theatre, it's fun time, with popcorn and Amitabh Bachchan.

Cut to 2003: It's movie time again. Father, mother and kids get comfortable on the couch. Mother switches on the home theatre system, and at the same time logs on to the Internet. The screen on the wall comes alive with Anjelina Jolie as Lara Croft. Is this fantasy? No. It's happening and it's happening now. Digital video is already an established fact and now online relay or streaming of movies is making its presence felt.

Video is going the same route as MP3 music, and distribution of films over the Net is fast catching on. Most Internet sports and news sites stream video to attract viewers to their sites.

ESPN has been relaying live sports over the Net and so has CNET, a news company that has a store of news videos for you to choose from and view. If you missed a particular news coverage on the TV or on the Net, you could always go to the archive and catch up on what you missed.

All this has been made possible through technologies such as Codecs (Compressor-Decompressor) that crunch the size of movies so that they can be rushed through the Internet across the world.

Frame by frame

Digital video is measured in terms of number of frames per second and by the size and the resolution of these frames. The total size requirement for video is huge, particularly if one wants NTSC (National Television Standards Committee, of